

AI at Work: Quick Reference

A practical guide to choosing the right task, prompting clearly, building repeatable workflows, and checking the result before it leaves your hands.

THE WORKING PRINCIPLE

Use AI to accelerate a bounded task. Keep a person accountable for the context, verification, and final decision.

01 Choose a good task

Start with work that is frequent, clearly described, and easy to check. AI is usually most useful as a first-draft partner, summarizer, organizer, or option generator.

- Good starting points: summarize non-sensitive material, draft routine communications, classify or organize information, prepare meeting agendas, and compare clearly stated options.
- Pause before use when the task involves high-impact decisions, confidential data, unclear ownership, or facts that cannot be independently checked.
- Define success first: what should improve, how will you measure quality, and what must remain a human decision?

02 Use a complete prompt

A strong prompt supplies the missing context and makes the expected result testable. Include only the pieces that matter for the task.

PROMPT PART	WHAT TO SPECIFY
ROLE	What expertise or point of view should the assistant use?
TASK	What exactly should it do? Use a clear action verb.
CONTEXT	Who is the audience? What background or source material matters?
FORMAT	What structure, length, tone, or level of detail do you need?
CONSTRAINTS	What must it include, avoid, preserve, or not assume?
CHECK	What should it flag as uncertain, missing, or requiring verification?

COPY-AND-ADAPT TEMPLATE

Act as [role]. Help me [task] for [audience]. Context/source material: [relevant details]. Return [format, length, tone]. Follow these constraints: [constraints]. Separate facts from assumptions, flag uncertainty, and list anything I should verify.

03 Useful prompt patterns

Summarize

Summarize the material for [audience] in [length]. Organize it as: key message, supporting points, decisions, open questions, and next steps. Do not add facts that are not in the source. Mark gaps.

Draft

Draft a [kind of message] to [audience] about [purpose]. Use a [tone] tone, keep it to [length], preserve these facts [facts], and do not promise or imply [constraints]. End with [call to action].

Compare

Compare [options] against [criteria]. Show a table of evidence, benefits, costs, risks, and unknowns. State assumptions separately. Do not choose for me; identify what information would change the comparison.

Improve

Review this draft for [criteria]. First list the three most important issues, then provide a revised version. Preserve the meaning and facts. Explain any substantive change: [draft].

Plan

Turn this goal into a practical plan for [timeframe]. Provide steps, owners/roles, dependencies, and a definition of done. Highlight risks and decisions that need human input. Goal/context: [details].

04 Turn a prompt into a workflow

For repeatable tasks, make the steps and hand-offs visible. Automate stable, low-risk transformations first; retain approval before external or consequential actions.

1 INPUT	2 PREPARE	3 AI STEP	4 CHECK	5 APPROVE	6 RECORD
Trigger and source	Clean, relevant context	Bounded transformation	Rules + spot check	Person owns release	Outcome and errors

- Begin with one workflow and a clear baseline: time spent, error rate, or turnaround time.
- Add a fallback for missing, malformed, low-confidence, or out-of-scope inputs.
- Keep an owner, a review step, and a way to correct or stop the workflow.

05 Review before you rely

Fluent writing is not evidence. Treat AI output as a draft until it passes checks suited to the task.

- **Accuracy:** Are names, dates, numbers, quotations, and claims correct? Check important claims against trusted sources.
- **Coverage:** Did it answer the actual question? What source, perspective, or exception may be missing?
- **Fit:** Is the tone, audience, format, and level of detail appropriate?
- **Risk:** Did you share only permitted data? Could bias, privacy, or reputational harm result?
- **Ownership:** Has the right person reviewed it and accepted responsibility for the action or decision?

RESPONSIBLE-USE STOP CHECK

Before entering information, ask: Is this tool approved? Is the data allowed here? Could this output influence a person, money, safety, rights, or a formal decision? If yes, use the approved process and required human review.